



THE UNIVERSITY OF
MELBOURNE

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE ADVISORY GROUP

Current students web estate

Findings & decision pack — a full-evidence review of how current-students content is delivered across the central site, the faculties and their schools.

University of Melbourne · June 2026

The University of Melbourne acknowledges the Traditional Owners of the unceded land on which we work, learn and live, and pays respect to their Elders, past and present, and to Indigenous Australians today.

Decision at a glance

A full crawl of the University's current-students web estate — **1,173 pages** across `students.unimelb.edu.au`, **9 faculty** sections and **3 school** sections — finds the estate is **85% unique, discipline-specific content**, not duplication. The service model is **structurally sound but the seams are broken**: six different URL conventions, careers content siloed across 9 faculties with zero cross-linking, `students.unimelb.edu.au` missing whole services that students need (placements, course planning), school-level sites splintering the experience, and ~50 broken pages.

DEAG is asked to endorse three things:

1. **Direction** — a *central-and-spoke* model (`students.unimelb.edu.au` owns the transactional spine + fills its gaps; faculties keep their discipline-specific estates under shared standards). **Not** full centralisation; **not** status quo.
2. **No-regrets actions now** — standard URL, a "where do I go for X" component, fix the broken links, and connect careers. These need no structural decision and can start immediately.
3. **A standards mandate + a scoped Phase 2** — so the seams actually get fixed and stay fixed.

1. Purpose & scope

The student web experience is delivered jointly by `students.unimelb.edu.au` (`students.unimelb.edu.au`) and current-students sections run independently by each faculty (and, in some cases, individual schools). DEAG asked whether that **service model is still working**, where content **overlaps or has gaps**, and what — if anything — should change.

This pack answers those questions from **direct evidence**: every reachable current-students page across the estate was crawled, classified and topic-tagged. It then sets out the options and the decision we recommend DEAG take.

In scope: `students.unimelb.edu.au` + the current-students sections of all 9 faculties + the 3 schools that run their own (Melbourne Business School, Biomedical Sciences, Melbourne Dental School). **Out of scope**: authenticated systems (`my.unimelb`, Canvas/LMS, SIS, Stop 1 service desk), prospective-student content, and staff content.

2. Method (and its limits)

A browser-based crawler walked each current-students section breadth-first, capturing for every page its content, word count, in-section structure, outbound links (where it sends students), a unique/duplicative classification, and topic tags. **1,173 pages** were captured.

Limitations, stated honestly: ABP/MSD hit a 250-page ceiling because of a large self-referencing studio archive (~700 further pages of one repeating type — counted as a single content class, not omitted findings). The `students.unimelb.edu.au` was mapped at IA + section-landing level, not leaf-by-leaf. Classification is automated (a page is "unique" if it carries substantive original prose, "link-farm" if it mostly routes elsewhere) and is indicative, not hand-audited. Cloudflare actively blocked conventional/headless crawling — a finding in itself for any future automated audit.

3. What we found

Finding 1 — The estate is large, and overwhelmingly *unique*

997 of 1,173 pages (85%) are unique, substantive content. Only ~4% are pure link-farms and ~7% are mixed. The dominant content is exactly what *can't* live centrally: **placements & WIL (186 pages)**, subjects & timetabling (174), course planning (107), research candidature (96). This is the single most important finding: **the faculty estate is real content, not redundant signposting**. "Just centralise it" is not a credible option.

Finding 2 — Every faculty hosts a real estate; the "link directory" picture was wrong

Earlier sampling suggested some faculties (ABP, FBE) were thin link directories. The full crawl disproves it: ABP runs **240 unique pages** (sample course plans, studios, mentoring); FFAM runs a substantive 37-page section (ensembles, facilities, forms); MDHS runs **104 unique pages** of clinical-placement compliance. What faculties *do* delegate is **transactional admin** — they correctly send students to students.unimelb.edu.au for enrolment, fees, exams. The duplication problem is **smaller and thinner** than feared; the *seam* problem is bigger.

Finding 3 — Six URL conventions for one idea

"Information for current students" lives at six different addresses: `/students` · `/current-students` · `/study/current-students` · `/study/student-resources` · `/study/current-student-information` · (and students.unimelb.edu.au). A student cannot guess their faculty's URL.

Finding 4 — Careers is the clearest failure: parallel everywhere, connected nowhere

8 of 9 faculties plus MBS run their own careers/employability content (mentoring, internships, industry programs) in parallel with the central Careers service — and the central and faculty careers pages **do not cross-link in either direction**. A student using the central career checklist may never discover their faculty's mentoring program, and vice-versa. This is the highest-value, lowest-cost fix in the estate.

Finding 5 — students.unimelb.edu.au has real gaps where every faculty has built

students.unimelb.edu.au covers the transactional spine well but has **no presence** in services every faculty provides: **placements & WIL** (186 faculty pages; central ≈ 0), **degree-specific course planning**, **discipline academic skills** (legal writing, lab reports, studio practice), **faculty forms** (no central forms index), and **program regulatory pathways** (LANTITE for teaching, Fitness-to-Practice / AHPRA for health). These gaps are *why* faculties build parallel sites.

Finding 6 — School-level fragmentation multiplies the experience

Three schools run their own current-students sites *beneath* their faculty: **MBS (61 pages**, plus its own "Career Elevation" service), **Biomedical Sciences (42)**, **Dental (4)**. A Biomedicine student can traverse **three** different "home" experiences — students.unimelb.edu.au, the MDHS faculty section, and the Biomedical school site — each with a different URL pattern and template.

Finding 7 — Quality debt is visible and fixable

~50 pages are broken or misrouting, concentrated in: Biomedical Sciences (18 — including 16 "major" pages with duplicate CMS slugs bouncing students to the *prospective* catalogue), FEIT (17 duplicate/broken URLs), ABP (6), MDHS (3), Arts (3), FBE (2). The Dental site even depends on case-sensitive paths (`/Forms` works, `/forms` 404s) and splits its own forms across two external form hosts.

Finding 8 — No page tells students "what's where"

Not one faculty section carries a consistent "for X go to students.unimelb.edu.au; for Y stay here" signpost. Students learn the split by trial and error, and faculty pages routinely re-explain students.unimelb.edu.au services (special consideration, leave of absence) that students.unimelb.edu.au owns definitively.

Finding 9 — The topic evidence sharpens the consolidation target (counts now corrected)

A topic-by-topic crawl (18 topics) pinpoints where consolidation pays. The **transactional spine** (enrolment, exams & results, special consideration, fees, library — ~105 content pages) has **only ~6 on the central domain**; the rest are faculty restatements of content students.unimelb.edu.au already owns — the single clearest target. **Scholarships** (faculties hold ~100 pages of generic process scaffolding while a central catalogue already exists) and the duplicated "Employability in X" / "Wellbeing + Ambassadors" landing pages are next. The raw topic counts were heavily **inflated by content-quality artefacts** — ABP/MSD's ~700-page studio archive, FEIT nesting its estate under `/orientation`, ~70 Law researcher bios, and a bare-"IT" tag mis-classifying FEIT content. These have now been **corrected in a cleaned dataset** (e.g. IT-systems 235→14, orientation 289→76, subjects & timetabling 319→174), so Appendix B reports the corrected content counts. The hygiene issues themselves (the archive, URL/CMS debt) remain to fix at source, independent of the unification decision.

Finding 10 — Current students are a ~7% tenant inside outward-facing faculty estates

A follow-up crawl of the **full faculty domains** (all 9 marketing sites, **2,363 pages** — the denominator the current-students slice never had) shows current-student content is only **~7% sign-posted** of each faculty's actual web presence. The rest is research, news, *about*, prospective *study* and industry/engagement — content built for prospective students, media and donors. Two facts sharpen the decision: **(1) there is no shared faculty IA to centralise into** — the dominant section differs in every faculty (Engineering is 76% a magazine, Fine Arts & Music 86% "about us", Education led by a research centre); **(2) most "faculty student content" is entangled with non-student content** — Law and FEIT explicitly section only 9 and 18 student pages despite ~195/204 being student-relevant, so it is not a portable estate. A current student's tasks will always sit *inside* an outward-facing site; the job is to make that thin layer findable and consistent, not to relocate it. (Evidence: *analysis/full-faculty-context.md*.)

Finding 11 — The fragmentation runs the full length of the lifecycle, not just current students

A cross-corpus join of all four estates — prospective (*study.unimelb* , 300 pages), current (*faculty + students.unimelb*), alumni (*www.unimelb/alumni* , 116) and the full faculty domains — finds the same fragmentation at every lifecycle stage, not only the current one. **Careers is authored at ~10 independent locations across four domains** (prospective, central, 8 faculties, alumni), and faculty student-mentoring is never linked to the alumni mentoring students graduate into. **Prospective is as fragmented as current** — 300 central pages *plus* ~210 faculty */study/* pages — so the apply→enrol handoff crosses a domain boundary with no shared vocabulary. **Alumni is largely current-student services re-hosted** on a fourth domain (careers, wellbeing, international), with no graduation→alumni bridge. And **research reputation is decoupled from research-student support** — MDHS hosts 63 research pages but only 1 HDR-candidature page. *Implication for DEAG*: a current-students-only mandate fixes one of three lifecycle handoffs; the seams students feel most — applying then enrolling, finishing then becoming alumni — sit *between* corpora and are the least owned. (Evidence: *analysis/lifecycle-cross-corpus.md*.)

4. The service-model verdict

The central-and-faculty division of labour is the right one — but it is being run without the connective tissue that makes it work. *students.unimelb.edu.au* is the correct owner of the transactional spine; faculties are the correct owners of placements, course plans, discipline skills and forms. What's missing is everything *between* them: consistent addressing, mutual signposting, a *students.unimelb.edu.au* presence for placements/course-planning, connected careers, consolidated school sites, and enforced standards. The fix is therefore **not** re-drawing ownership (centralise/decentralise) — it is **engineering the seams**.

5. Discussion points for DEAG

1. **Autonomy vs consistency.** Faculties have invested years in genuinely useful content. Standards must be *mandated* (the URL chaos proves advisory guidance has failed) without gutting faculty ownership. How much standardisation will DEAG require, and with what authority?
2. **The 85%-unique reality.** It takes "lift-and-shift to *students.unimelb.edu.au*" off the table. Does DEAG accept that the goal is a *connected federation*, not a single site?
3. **School-level sites (MBS, Biomedical, Dental).** Tolerate, standardise, or consolidate into their faculty? MBS in particular is effectively a second business-school experience under FBE.
4. **The careers silo.** The clearest single win — but who owns *students.unimelb.edu.au*↔faculty careers bridge, and will faculties agree to embed the central tools?
5. **students.unimelb.edu.au gaps.** Filling placements / course-planning gateways means the central team owns *new* content. Is there capacity, or should these be thin "connector" pages that point into faculty content?
6. **Governance teeth.** What mandate will DEAG actually back — standards as policy, with audit and consequences, or another advisory guideline?
7. **Personalisation as an accelerator.** If Optimizely + Tealium (CDP) are in the University's martech stack, a *personalised students.unimelb.edu.au* could surface the right faculty content to a known student without moving any pages — potentially leapfrogging migration. **This needs confirming** (see decision ask).

6. Options (recalibrated to the evidence)

Option	What it is	Verdict against the evidence
A. Full centralisation	Move faculty CS content to students.unimelb.edu.au	Reject. 997 unique, discipline-specific pages (clinical compliance, studios, legal skills) cannot be owned or maintained centrally.
B. Status quo + light governance	Keep everything, add advisory standards	Insufficient. Advisory standards already failed (6 URL conventions). Doesn't fix careers, gaps or school sites.
C. Central-and-spoke with standards (recommended)	students.unimelb.edu.au owns the transactional spine and fills its gaps (placements, course-planning, careers bridge); faculties keep discipline content under a mandated template, URL and signposting standard; school sites consolidated	Best fit. Matches the 85%-unique reality, fixes the seams, preserves faculty investment, achievable in ~12 months.
D. Central-and-spoke + CDP personalisation	Option C plus a personalised students.unimelb.edu.au (Optimizely/Tealium) that surfaces a student's faculty content automatically	Strongest if the martech exists. Adds a modern, personalised front door with no extra migration. Contingent on stack + data.

Recommendation: adopt C now, and upgrade to D if Optimizely/Tealium are confirmed.

7. The decision asked of DEAG

- **Decision 1 — Endorse the direction (C/D), ruling out full centralisation and status quo.**
- **Decision 2 — Approve the no-regrets actions to begin immediately** (Section 8). These deliver visible improvement inside a quarter and need no structural change.
- **Decision 3 — Mandate a standards baseline and commission a scoped Phase 2** (students.unimelb.edu.au gap-fill + school-site consolidation policy + governance with audit). Confirm whether Optimizely/Tealium are available to determine C vs D.

8. No-regrets actions (start now, regardless of the above)

Action	Why	Effort
Standardise the URL to <code>faculty.unimelb.edu.au/students</code> + 301-redirect the five variants	Discoverability; kills the 404 trap	Low
Ship a "Where do I go for X?" component on every faculty CS page	Directly fixes Finding 8 — the single highest-impact student fix	Low–Med
Fix the ~50 broken/misrouting pages (Biomedical 18, FEIT 17 first)	Removes the worst quality debt; stops routing students to the wrong catalogue	Low
Cross-link careers both ways (students.unimelb.edu.au ↔ every faculty)	Fixes the clearest failure in the estate	Low
Publish the standard CS template (key contacts · course planning · placements · faculty life · forms · "where to go")	Baseline every faculty/school section can adopt	Med

Appendix A — Measured evidence (per unit)

Unit	Level	Pages	Unique	Mixed	Link-farm	Broken	CS URL pattern
Law	Faculty	195	162	10	23	0	/students
FEIT	Faculty	204	174	13	0	17	/students
Arts	Faculty	91	51	24	13	3	/students
Science	Faculty	94	91	2	0	1	/students

Unit	Level	Pages	Unique	Mixed	Link-farm	Broken	CS URL pattern
ABP / MSD	Faculty	250*	240	4	0	6	/current-students
FBE	Faculty	36	31	3	0	2	/students
Education	Faculty	47	32	10	5	0	/study/current-students
FFAM	Faculty	37	28	4	5	0	/current-students
MDHS	Faculty	112	104	4	1	3	/study/current-students
MBS	School (FBE)	61	60	1	0	0	/students
Biomedical Sci.	School (MDHS)	42	21	3	0	18	/study/current-student-information
Dental	School (MDHS)	4	3	1	0	0	/study/student-resources
Total		1,173	997 (85%)	79	47	50	6 conventions

* ABP capped at 250; a further ~700 studio-archive pages of one repeating type were not individually crawled.

Appendix B — Topic evidence (18 topics)

Page counts are **cleaned content totals** from the corrected dataset (`data/clean/`) — profile/archive pages, namespace artefacts and over-broad tags removed. The raw → cleaned moves are in `data/clean/topic-false-positive-rates.csv`.

Topic	Pages	Verdict	What the evidence shows
Subjects & timetabling	174	mixed	Studio archive (~140 pages) now excluded; the remainder is a thin central-owned timetabling spine echoed by faculties.
Orientation	76	faculty layer	FEIT's /orientation path-nesting removed (FEIT ~48); genuine orientation is a thin faculty welcome layer.
Research candidature	96	faculty-owned	Legit (milestones, studios, funding); ~70 Law researcher bios now excluded; faculties own the candidature lifecycle spine.
IT & systems	14	central-owned	Mis-classified FEIT content removed; the genuine IT estate is ~14 — central owns the Student IT / LMS / portal spine.
Transactional admin (enrol · exams · special-con · fees · library)	~105	central-owned	Only ~6 on the central domain ; the rest are faculty restatements — the clearest consolidation target.
Student life	68	faculty-owned	Largely legit (clubs, mentoring, awards); Science committee-member bios now excluded.
Forms & admin	23	mixed	Over-broad "form/admin" matches removed; genuine forms pages are few but scattered, with no central index.
Course planning	107	faculty-owned	Degree-specific plans; MBS + Biomedical ≈ 46%; thin central-overlap.
Placements & WIL	186	faculty-owned	MDHS 47% (clinical compliance); near-zero central overlap; the gap is discoverability, not duplication.
Contacts & support	26	mixed	Over-broad "contact/help/support" matches removed; genuine pages are mostly restatements of central wellbeing/careers.
Careers & employability	63	mixed	Legit core (pathways, internships, mentoring) + a duplicated "Employability in X" layer.
Scholarships	100	consolidate	Central holds zero; mostly generic process scaffolding → fold into central <code>scholarships.unimelb.edu.au</code> .

Topic	Pages	Verdict	What the evidence shows
International	74	mislabelled	~80% is outbound mobility; genuine inbound support (visas/OSHC) is absent and central-owned.
Graduation	0	misnomer	Almost entirely HDR candidature + honours, not ceremonies (re-tagged to research candidature); the apply-to-graduate ceremony spine is missing.
Clubs & events	46	faculty-owned	Community content; only the generic club-admin wrapper overlaps the central site.
Wellbeing & health	37	mixed	Half is MDHS clinical compliance; 6 near-duplicate "Wellbeing + Ambassadors" landings to collapse.
Inclusion & equity	18	consolidate	~18 real pages parallel-reinvent the central service.
Academic skills	40	central-overlap	Discipline skills are legit; generic landings duplicate the central service.

Evidence base: `crawl/pages/*.json` (1,173 records) + cleaned dataset `data/clean/`, `analysis/`, `data/`. Full corpus available on request.